the Tamil country from the North, most probably from the Karnataka region, spoke Prakrit rather than Tamil and were apparently strong enough to overthrow the incumbent Tamil rulers and disrupt the existing social order, confiscating land given to the Brahmins.[12] However, there now appears to be a growing body of opinion that argues that there was no Kalabhra dark age, though there may have been a period of turmoil, *kalavaram* meaning 'turmoil' in Tamil. I remain unconvinced.

What is indisputable is that during this supposed Kalabhra ascendancy there was a dramatic expansion of Buddhist centres of learning at Conjeeveram (Kanchipuram) and Nagapattinam, creating what could almost be called a second Buddhist renaissance in the South, now centred on the Cauvery River delta. Students came to study here from as far afield as Gandhara and China and took the new teachings of Madyamaka away with them. And as it spread north and east so these Madyamaka teachings solidified into Mahayana, the Great Vehicle, today followed by the majority of Buddhists worldwide.

Other schools of Buddhism also flourished side by side with Madyamaka. The seventeenth-century Lankan text known as the *Gandhavamsa*, or 'History of Literature', speaks of Kanchipuram as one of three major centres of early Theravada learning in South India and of ten great teachers of Kanchipuram, beginning with the fifth-century theologian Buddhadatta, who in his own writings speaks of a king named Achchuta Vikranta of the Kalabhra clan ruling over the country from his capital at Kaveripattinam. Today the site of the former port of Kaveripattinam is better known as Poompuhar or Poompatinam ('estuary town') and is little more than a collection of fishermen's huts strung along a sandy beach. Little evidence of a glorious past has survived and little has emerged from surveys. However, the submerged wharves and piers of an ancient harbour have